

Fight the Man



ADAPTED FROM 'THE GUIDE TO PUBLIC ORDER SITUATIONS' FROM THE UK. ←

and Get Away *Safely*!

Code of Nonviolence

"We are fighting to dismantle the system of violence that is being inflicted upon the earth and its inhabitants by political and corporate powers that be; the violence which leads to the destruction of earth's biodiversity and integrity, the torture and extinction of its species, and the oppression and genocide of its peoples, in the interests of capital profit. With compassion and respect for all life we will fight, by any means necessary, to end this violence of injustice." -Wild and Free

This guide is not to show you how to incite or conduct a riot. It does not promote violence or try to make moral judgments on the efficacy of certain tactics over others. Nor does it want to dwell on the various definitions of 'violence' and 'non-violence' and partake in those arguments which plague and hinder the activist community. It is merely a compilation of suggestions on how to safely survive situations created by police violence and confrontation, once such a situation has occurred. Trainings which consider throwing and running as acts of violence and advise you against those actions have not prepared us for police overreaction of recent (as we have seen during J18 Reclaim the Streets and N30 anti-WTO protests). This guide tries to fill in, where typical non-violence trainings may leave out, practical advice on how to get out of such situations without going to jail or the hospital, and without compromising your body or your voice.

Yes, we live in a police state. Martial law is a reality. The cops are capable and overly willing to use excessive force to squelch the messages of protesters and disperse any crowds gathered for the purpose of interfering with bu\$ine\$\$ as usual. Going into a demo or a street party, keep in mind that they are much better equipped and trained for close combat than you. They are confident that the law is behind them and against you. So beating the police is about outwitting them, not necessarily hitting them over the head.

Know Thy Enemy---The objectives of the cops are:

- 1) To break the spirit of the crowd by intimidating and breaking up the crowd into 'manageable' portions.
- 2) To provoke violence to justify their own actions and to pick up 'leaders'.
- 3) Stop the trouble spreading by surrounding the crowd.
- 4) Gather evidence for later.

The aims of the protester -- (is not to "win", but to be unhurt and still free.)

- 1) You and your friends get away safely, rather than fighting
- 2) Cause embarrassment and economic damage to your original target, rather than fighting. (your original target shouldn't be the cops.)
- 3) Helping others by administering first aid and de-arresting, rather than fighting

Preparations before going into possible (dis)-order situations:

Affinity groups:

Affinity groups are small groups of people (ideally those who know each other well and have worked together in the past) who work together as a unit as circumstances arise. Meeting before hand to discuss issues and possible reactions will help the effectiveness of the group during the real thing. If affinity groups cannot be formed before going out, at the least have a buddy to look out for and act with them when situations arise.

Dress code: Not that you want to be in full armor at a street party, but you want to be discrete and adaptable, in clothing that is easy to apply or discard. Things to consider:

- 1) Surveillance: Masks make it difficult to identify individuals and if everyone wears masks none will stand out. Hoods will cover most of your face and baseball caps protect you from most cameras mounted above. Sunglasses can give good protection against harmful rays including UV and CCTV.
- 2) Rubber bullets/Bean bag pellets: Placards and banners make good shields, and light strips of plastic under clothing

(especially on the forearms) may help. The best protection, however may be a good pair of running shoes.

3) Gasses (pepper spray, tear gas, CS gas, etc.): Lots of water to rinse out your eyes and face. Baking soda in water or diluted vinegar help as a wash. Whatever you do, don't rub it in or take a hot shower. Get away, let the wind blow it off your skin and clothing. Of course gas masks or goggles would be most effective, but we have seen that Martial Law may make the possession of such masks illegal and therefore another excuse for them to hassle you.

4) Baton charges: Banners can be used as a barrier for police line charges. Use plastic tarps rather than sheets for banners. Wrap the ends in around themselves so the police can't easily grab it.

The Defensive: You should always be defending. Be securing a building or an escape route, strengthening your position on the street, barricading or protecting and helping others.

1) Keep looking outwards from the crowd. If someone is being administered first aid, stand facing away from them.

2) Form cordons around anything the police want. (buildings, sound equipment, etc.)

3) Practice dancing with your back to the sound system.

4) Someone should watch the police from a good vantage point and inform the crowd of police movements.

5) Sitting down is good for dissuading police charging but only in large numbers. Sometimes sitting is not really worth it.

Horses are unpredictable. Particularly violent cops, especially those employing gases or rubber bullets, may be dangerous to sit in front of.

6) Throwing is a defensive act. It may not be wise to throw stuff at the best of times, that will only provoke them and make them want to hit you harder. If you want to throw, do it defensively, strategically, and en masse-- a constant hail of debris will create a 'sterile area' where the police will not want to go. Remember: don't throw to attack or cause injury. Throw from the front and then disappear into the crowd. Only wankers throw from the back.

--gas canisters can be thrown or kicked back (or away from the crowd at least) before they explode. Be careful! Don't pick up with bare hands as they can be very hot. They will explode.

- 7) Barricades can be more hassle than they are worth. Impassable blockades may be an inconvenience to you when you need to run. And remember whatever you put on the road, you may be dragged over later, so leave out barbed wire. The best barricades are random material strewn all over.
- 8) The best defense is chaos. If situations change constantly they cannot keep up. Keep moving. Change your appearance. Open new directions and possibilities. Be unpredictable.

Basic police choreography

With any rowdy crowd, the police will be trying to break it up. They will try to disperse crowds using baton line charges, horse charges, vehicles, gases and rubber/wooden bullets. The dance steps will include one or more of these:

- 1) Cops in lines will surround you.
- 2) Either from the middle or one side, the cop lines will force everyone onto the sidewalk trying to create 'spectators' and 'actors' out of the crowd.
- 3) Baton/horse/gas attack to lower morale.
- 4) Loud speaker, concussion grenades, or bright lights if at night to disorient the crowd.
- 5) Line charges will slowly push the crowd down the street to where they want you (rush of cops -> fall back -> strengthen line -> repeat).

Stop the lines from forming!

Surrounding you, preventing you from going where you want to go, and pushing you down the street to where they want you to go, all require the police to be in a tight line. It is important to prevent the first lines from forming. If the crowd seems volatile, they will hold back and form their lines a distance away. But if the crowd is hanging around looking confused and passive they will sneak in and form the lines amongst you.

- don't stand and watch them. Keep moving.
- don't look like you'll let them anywhere near you.
- spot gaps in the crowd and fill them. stick together.
- figure out where they want to go and get there first.
- get long tarp banners to the front to stop them from advancing or breaking the crowd.

- protect your escape routes by standing in front of them.
- get those people who turned into 'spectators' back into the crowd and moving around.

Now they may just charge and start arresting. At least you are in a stronger position to deal and your escape routes are secured. Whatever happens next, don't stand there waiting for it. Keep moving and acting defensively.

If they have blocked your only exit try...

- counter advancing: this involves moving your lines into theirs, thus gaining more space and opening up more exits. Use the front line as a solid wall, linking arms and moving slowly forward. Use the banner as a plow (this prevents them from breaking the line but they can still hit you).
 - reforming: always look for ways to increase your numbers, by joining up with other groups and absorbing stragglers.
- Everyone has to get out and you'll stand a better chance of getting out unharmed, with all your belongings and equipment if you leave together at the same time.

Snatch squads the police will often want to isolate and arrest individuals out of a crowd. Groups of cops will surround a person, and half of them will arrest while half will stand in front of them and hit anyone who will get in the way. Once they have the person, he/she will be taken away behind police lines.

1. Keep the crowd moving together
2. Spot the squad forming and approaching.
3. If there is a target person, get him/her the hell out of the area
4. Link arms in an impenetrable wall in the squads' path
5. Surround the squad once in the crowd to intimidate them
6. If you do get grabbed and pressure pointed, keep your head and arms moving. Don't fight them if you can help it or you might be faced with assault charges too.

De-arresting the best time to do this is as soon as the snatch has happened. You need a group of people who know how to break grips and some people to act as blocks. Once you have your person back all link arms and disappear in to the crowd. The police may try to snatch back or arrest one of the de-arresters. Bear in mind that the de-arrester may end up with heavier charges than the original arrestee if caught.

These are a few of the most probable situations and suggestions of possible tactics to deal with them. Keep in mind that although the police are trained to fight and deal with you, they are just doing their job and following orders. Watch for their weak points and times that they are vulnerable, such as during shift changes or while they are waiting for the order from above. The best preparation before going into possible situations is discussion and communication with your peers. Don't get preoccupied fighting the cops and remember your original target. Don't let the stress level lead to infighting; that's exactly what they want to see. Maintain solidarity with your fellow protesters and recognize your common goal to keep yourselves from getting arrested or getting hurt.

